

The Town Mouse and the Country Mouse

A country mouse lived beneath the floor of a quiet farmhouse. His meals were plain: grain, nuts, and pieces of cheese saved from the pantry. One autumn day his cousin from the town came to visit. The town mouse was neatly dressed and spoke of markets, kitchens, and houses with many rooms. When the country mouse set out his humble supper, the visitor tried to be polite but could not hide his surprise.

"You must come to town," said the visitor. "There are cakes, fruit, roasted meat, and cheese richer than anything here." The country mouse was curious, so the next morning they set off. In the town house, the country mouse stared at a table covered with wonderful food left after a feast. He tasted sweet crumbs, soft bread, and a piece of pear. For a moment he thought his cousin had been right: this was a grand life.

Suddenly a door opened. The mice fled beneath a cabinet as servants entered the room. When the servants left, the country mouse crept out again. He reached for another crumb, but a cat leaped from behind a chair. The cousins escaped through a crack in the wall, their hearts pounding. The town mouse sighed. "That happens sometimes," he said. "But the food is worth it."

The country mouse stayed another night, but he could not sleep. Every creak sounded like a footstep, every shadow looked like the cat. In the morning he thanked his cousin for the visit and began the journey home. Back at the farmhouse, he ate a dry grain beside the familiar wall. It was not luxurious, but he could hear the wind outside and know that no cat would spring from the dark.

The town mouse later visited the country and found the meals boring. The cousins understood then that neither life was perfect for everyone. One valued abundance and excitement; the other valued safety and peace. They stopped trying to persuade each other. The country mouse had learned that a simple meal enjoyed without fear can taste better than a feast guarded by danger, while the town mouse learned that comfort means different things to different hearts.